

How Companies can Choose a DMS

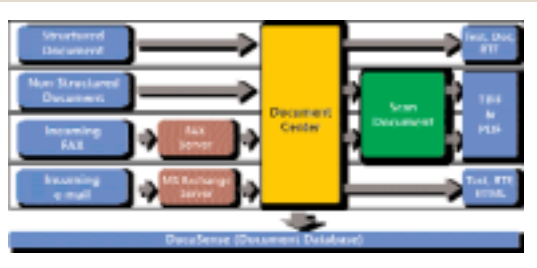
Electronic Data Management Systems (EDMS), or DMS, are commercial, off-the-shelf software packages. A database management system (DBMS) is designed to store structured data—essentially data elements and data records. A Document Management System, on the other hand, can store, retrieve and manage unstructured information objects—files, text, spreadsheets, images, sound clips, multi-media and compound documents. An IT staff's involvement is to configure and install the package, train the users, provide help-desk support and keep the servers running smoothly.

The Document Management System takes care of the back-end jobs of an organisation such as the management and archiving of records. What remains is the front-end work, which includes e-mail messages, word processing documents and even voice-mail messages. For many organisations, the front-

end integration is the most important consideration in product selection. Today, many vendors offer support for both proprietary clients on private networks and also Internet connectivity through Web gateways.

Companies that have implemented Document Management Systems emphasise the need to examine business-critical objectives before embarking on such projects. For businesses such as engineering, insurance and pharmaceuticals, the goal of automating the document management process is to get control of, and increase the efficiency of the flow of documents that support their business-processing insurance claims, and creating and getting approval for new drugs.

So how to choose the right product? A



good Document Management System should obviously make it easy to locate documents, track the history of changes, prevent accidental loss of work and provide a basis for knowledge management. The first two fall into the document profiling area. The latter are normally part of version control. Besides this, the system should include all possible file types that a company uses—especially e-mail messages—and the filing and locating documents should be simple, both when working

ing files on the Windows explorer. Fill in all the document profile information (Description, Client, Practise, Client, Author and Project).

This information will be used for all the documents imported. All imported documents will be included in the QDocs by their unique Reference Numbers. If you want to include the filenames of the documents in the description, click the 'Include original filename' option. Start importing by clicking on Import.

Add clients easily by clicking **Tools > Clients > Add**—enter the information and click save

Simple addition

To add clients, click **Tools > Clients > Add**. When you've finished typing the information, click Save, or else click Undo to discard changes. Use the arrows buttons to move to first, previous, next or last client in the list. You can use the Browse button to search for a client by the company name. Click Edit to edit the client details. Projects : If you need to add new projects, click the Add button and the project name field will be shown in the workbench window. The Date created is automatically entered when adding a new project. When you're finished with a specific project, mark it as Inactive by disabling the option control and it will stop appearing in the workbench window. You can make it active again simply by enabling the option control.

Practises: Use the Practise option to categorise your documents by your business practises. Specify the location where you want the documents to be

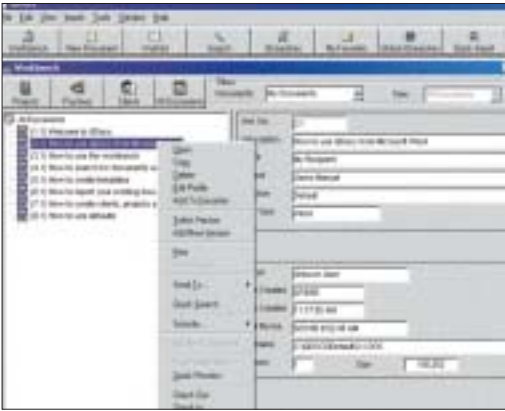
New Projects can be added and appear in the workbench

File your documents according to business practises for easy access later

saved by QDocs. Use the browse button to create a new folder.

Working the workbench

The workbench is a graphical representation of your documents. The tree view will show your documents in the following order: projects, practises and clients. You



Right-clicking on the tree view gives you the popup menu